“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 24

Explanation of the Ātmārāma Verse

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 May Śrī Caitanya, the eastern mountain from which the sun rises, protect us. Revealing the rays of meaning of the sun-like *ātmārāma* verse, He dispelled the darkness of the world.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 Then Sanātana clasped the Lord’s feet and once more humbly spoke:

4 “I have heard that once, at Sārvabhauma’s place, You explained a single verse in eighteen ways.

5 “Even sages who delight in the ātmā and are free from the knots of the heart render causeless devotion to Urukrama, for such are the qualities of Hari.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.7.10)

6 Hearing of this wonder, my mind is filled with longing. If You kindly tell me, my ears will be soothed.”

7 The Lord said, “I am a madman, and Sārvabhauma takes the madness in My words to be the truth.

8 I do not remember anything of what I babbled then. Yet by the strength of your company something may come to My mind.

9 No meaning comes to Me of itself; whatever is revealed comes by the strength of the company of all of you.”

10 This verse has eleven perfectly pure words, and in each of them, taken separately, many different meanings shine brightly.

11 The word *ātmā* has seven meanings: Brahman, the body, the mind, effort (*yatna*), steadfastness (*dhṛti*), intelligence (*buddhi*) and nature (*svabhāva*).

12 “The word *ātmā* is used for the body, the mind, Brahman, nature, steadfastness and intelligence, and also for effort.” (Viśva-prakāśa)

13 Those who delight in these seven are *ātmārāmas*. I shall enumerate the kinds of *ātmārāmas* later.

14 Hear, Sanātana, the meanings of the word *muni* and the others. I shall first give the meaning of each separately and afterwards combine them.

15 The word *muni* means one given to contemplation (*manana-śīla*). It also means one who is silent, an ascetic, one who keeps vows, a renunciant (*yati*), a seer (*ṛṣi*) and a sage (*muni*).

16 The word *nirgrantha* means one free from the knot of ignorance, and also one devoid of knowledge of the Vedic scriptures with their injunctions and prohibitions.

17 Fools, the low-born, *mlecchas* and others who are devoid of scripture; one who hoards wealth; and one who has no wealth — all these are also called *nirgrantha*.

18 “The prefix *nir* is used in the senses of certainty, sequence, construction and prohibition. The word *grantha* means wealth, a literary work, and also the stringing of letters into words.” (Viśva-prakāśa)

19 The word *urukrama* means He whose step (*krama*) is great. The word *krama* means a step, the placing forward of the foot.

20 *Krama* also means power, trembling, orderly arrangement and stepping forth (*ākramaṇa*). By the movement of His feet He made the three worlds tremble.

21 “Even a learned man who could count the atoms of the earth — who among such could count the powers of Viṣṇu? When His unchecked stride shook the universe from *pradhāna*, the abode of the equilibrium of the three *guṇas*, up to Satyaloka, it was He who held Satyaloka fast.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.7.40)

22 In His all-pervading form He pervades everything, and by His potency He sustains and nourishes it. By His potency of sweetness (*mādhurya-śakti*) He sustains Goloka, and by His majesty (*aiśvarya*) the spiritual sky, Paravyoma.

23 By His potency of *māyā* He creates the universes and all else in orderly succession. Thus is the meaning of the word *urukrama* determined.

24 “*Krama* means power and orderly arrangement; *krama* also means movement and trembling.” (Viśva-prakāśa)

25 The word *kurvanti* is in the *parasmaipada*, the voice used when an action is done for another. It shows that the worship is meant for Kṛṣṇa’s happiness.

26 “Roots marked with the *svarita* accent or with the indicatory letter *ñ* take the *ātmanepada* endings when the fruit of the action is meant for the agent himself.” (Pāṇini, 1.3.72)

27 The word *hetu* (motive) means other desires, beginning with the desire for enjoyment. They are chiefly of three kinds: enjoyment (*bhukti*), mystic perfection (*siddhi*) and liberation (*mukti*).

28 *Bhukti*, enjoyment, is of endless kinds; the *siddhis* are eighteen; and *mukti* is of five kinds.

29 Devotion in which these are absent is *ahaitukī*, causeless. By it the playful Śrī Kṛṣṇa comes under control.

30 The word *bhakti* has ten meanings: one is *sādhana-bhakti*, and *prema-bhakti* is of nine kinds.

31 It is proclaimed as marked by *rati*, marked by *prema* and so on, as having the form of *bhāva*, and as marked by *mahābhāva*.

32 The *rati* of devotees in *śānta-rasa* grows up to *prema*; the *rati* of devotees in *dāsya-rasa* reaches the stage of *rāga*.

33 The *rati* of His friends reaches up to *anurāga*, and the affection of His father, mother and other elders likewise reaches *anurāga*.

34 The *rati* of His beloveds reaches the limit of *mahābhāva*. Thus I have told the glory of the meaning of the word *bhakti*.

35 Now hear the explanation of the words *ittham-bhūta-guṇaḥ*. The word *ittham-bhūta* has its own meaning, and the word *guṇa* another.

36 The word *ittham-bhūta* means He who is full of perfect bliss, before whom the bliss of Brahman is like a blade of grass.

37 “O Guru of the world, now that I am immersed in the pure ocean of joy that comes from seeing You face to face, all other joys — even the bliss of Brahman — seem to me like the water in a calf’s hoofprint.” (Hari-bhakti-sudhodaya, 14.36)

38 He attracts all, delights all and is the great elixir of *rasa*. By His own power He makes one forget everything else.

39 Their mere scent makes one give up the happiness of enjoyment, liberation and mystic perfection. By the extraordinary power of His qualities He binds the heart through His mercy.

40 Here there is no scriptural reasoning or weighing of conclusions. This happens by the very nature of His qualities, in which lies the essence of sweetness.

41 The word *guṇa* means Kṛṣṇa’s qualities, which are endless. In His form, eternal and conscious, and in His qualities, everything is perfect bliss.

42 His own nature is full of majesty, sweetness and compassion. In His affection for His devotees His generosity goes so far that He gives even Himself.

43 He has extraordinary qualities — His form, His *rasa*, His fragrance and others — and by one quality or another He attracts each one’s mind.

44 He stole the minds of Sanaka and the other Kumāras by His fragrance and other qualities, and He stole Śukadeva’s mind through the hearing of His pastimes.

45 “The breeze that bore the fragrance of tulasī, mingled with the pollen of the lotus-eyed Lord’s lotus feet, entered their nostrils and stirred both their minds and their bodies, though they were devoted to the imperishable Brahman.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.15.43)

46 “O royal sage, although I was firmly established in transcendence of the *guṇas*, my mind was captivated by the pastimes of Uttamaśloka, and so I studied this narration.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.1.9)

47 By the beauty of His divine body He steals the minds of the *gopīs*; Rukmiṇī and the other queens are attracted by hearing of His beauty and qualities.

48 “Seeing Your face framed by curling locks and graced by the beauty of Your earrings, Your cheeks, the nectar of Your lips and Your smiling glance, and beholding Your two arms that grant fearlessness and Your chest, the sole delight of Śrī, we have become Your maidservants.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.29.39)

49 “O beauty of the worlds, Your qualities enter the ears of those who hear of them and remove the distress of their bodies, and Your form is, for the eyes of those who see, the attainment of every goal. Having heard of them, O Acyuta, my heart, casting off shame, enters into You.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.52.37)

50 By the song of His flute Kṛṣṇa steals the minds of Lakṣmī and others, and of all the young women of the world, each in a fitting mood.

51 “O Lord, we do not know by what merit this one has gained the right to touch the dust of Your feet. Longing for it, Śrī, the best of women, renounced all desires and practised austerities, keeping her vows for a very long time.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.16.36)

52 “O Kṛṣṇa, what woman in the three worlds, enchanted by the song of Your flute with its sweet, nectarean notes, would not stray from the conduct of the noble? Seeing this form of Yours, the beauty of the three worlds, even cows, birds, trees and deer bristle with rapture.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.29.40)

53 Women who are like elders He attracts in parental love (*vātsalya*), and men in the moods of servitude, friendship and others.

54 Birds, beasts, trees and creepers — all that moves and does not move — Kṛṣṇa’s qualities attract, making them mad with love (*prema*).

55 The word *hariḥ* has many meanings, two of which are foremost: He takes away all that is inauspicious, and, bestowing love (*prema*), He steals the mind.

56 Whoever remembers Him, in whatever way, He frees from the four kinds of distress.

57 “As a blazing fire turns firewood to ashes, so, O Uddhava, devotion to Me burns up all sins.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.14.19)

58 Then He destroys ignorance and the *karma* that obstructs devotion, and He manifests *prema*, the fruit of hearing and the other practices.

59 Then by His own qualities He steals the body, senses and mind. So merciful is Kṛṣṇa, and such are His qualities.

60 He makes one give up the four goals of human life and steals everyone’s mind. Thus I have told the chief meaning of the word *hari*.

61 The two words *ca* and *api* are indeclinables (*avyaya*): whatever meaning one applies to them, that meaning they take.

62 Still, seven chief meanings of *ca* are given, and the word *api* has seven well-known chief meanings.

63 "*Ca* is used in the senses of *anvācaya* (adding a secondary item), *samāhāra* (combining into a whole), *anyonya* (reciprocity), *samuccaya* (conjunction), *yatnāntara* (another effort), *pāda-pūraṇa* (filling out the foot of a verse) and *avadhāraṇa* (certainty)." (Viśva-prakāśa)

64 "*Api* is used in the senses of *sambhāvanā* (possibility), *praśna* (question), *śaṅkā* (doubt), *garhā* (censure) and *samuccaya* (conjunction), as well as for fitting application (*yukta-padārtha*) and for action at will (*kāmacāra-kriyā*)." (Viśva-prakāśa)

65 Thus the meanings of the eleven words have been determined. Now I shall give the meaning of the verse, applying each meaning as it fits.

66 The word *brahma* means the Truth that is greater than all; in His own nature and majesty no one is His equal.

67 "Because of His greatness (*bṛhattva*) and His power to nourish and expand all (*bṛṁhaṇatva*), the wise know Him as the Supreme Brahman. O Soul of all, unchanging One on whom the *yogīs* meditate, obeisance unto You." (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 1.12.57)

68 "Because He pervades all (*ātatatva*) and is the progenitor of all (*mātṛtva*), Hari is the Supreme Ātmā." (Bhāvārtha-dīpikā)

69 That word *brahma* means Svayam Bhagavān, the Lord Himself, the non-dual Knowledge, without whom nothing else exists.

70 "The knowers of the Truth call the non-dual knowledge the Truth; it is named Brahman, Paramātmā and Bhagavān." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.2.11)

71 That non-dual Truth is Kṛṣṇa, Svayam Bhagavān. He is real in all three phases of time; the scriptures are the evidence.

72 “Before creation I alone existed; there was nothing else — neither effect, nor cause, nor That which is beyond them. After creation this whole world is not other than Me, and what remains after its dissolution is also I.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.33)

73 By the word *ātmā* is meant Kṛṣṇa, whose very nature is greatness: He pervades all, witnesses all, and is the supreme form.

74 “Because He pervades all and is the progenitor of all, Hari is the Supreme Ātmā.” (Bhāvārtha-dīpikā)

75 For attaining that Kṛṣṇa there are three kinds of *sādhana* — *jñāna*, *yoga* and *bhakti* — each with its own characteristics.

76 Through the three *sādhanas* Bhagavān appears in three forms: He is manifest as Brahman, as Paramātmā and as Bhagavān Himself.

77 “The knowers of the Truth call the non-dual knowledge the Truth; it is named Brahman, Paramātmā and Bhagavān.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.2.11)

78 Though the words *brahma* and *ātmā* denote Kṛṣṇa, in their conventional usage (*rūḍhi-vṛtti*) they mean the featureless Brahman and the indwelling Lord (Antaryāmī).

79 On the path of knowledge He is manifest as the featureless Brahman; on the path of *yoga* He appears in the form of the Antaryāmī, the indwelling Lord.

80 Devotion is of two kinds, *rāga-bhakti* and *vidhi-bhakti*; and the Lord’s forms are two: Svayam Bhagavān, the Lord Himself, and Bhagavān.

81 By *rāga-bhakti* one attains Svayam Bhagavān in Vraja; by *vidhi-bhakti* one goes to Vaikuṇṭha in the body of an associate (*pārṣada*).

82 “This Bhagavān, the son of the gopī, is not so easily attained by the embodied, nor by the jñānīs, nor by those who have realized the self, as He is by those who have devotion.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.9.21)

83 “Those whose limbs thrill with rapture and are wet with tears of loving agitation as they speak together of the glories of their Lord; who follow the Lord of the gods and have left *yama* and the other disciplines far behind; whose nature we ourselves long to have — they go to Vaikuṇṭha, which is above us.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.15.25)

84 These worshippers are of three kinds: those without desire (*akāma*), those who desire liberation (*mokṣa-kāma*) and those who have every kind of desire (*sarva-kāma*).

85 “Whether he is without desire, full of every desire, or desirous of liberation, a person of broad intelligence should worship the Supreme Person with intense *bhakti-yoga*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.3.10)

86 *Udāra-dhīḥ* means intelligent: if a person can discern, then even for the sake of his own desires he worships Kṛṣṇa.

87 Without *bhakti* no *sādhana* can give its fruit. *Bhakti*, independent and powerful, gives every fruit.

88 Other *sādhanas* are like the teats on a goat’s neck. Therefore an intelligent person worships Hari.

89 “O Arjuna, best of the Bhāratas, four kinds of pious people worship Me: the distressed, the inquisitive, the seeker of wealth, and the one who has knowledge.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 7.16)

90 The distressed and the seeker of wealth I count among those with desires (*sakāma*); the inquisitive and the one who has knowledge I regard as desirous of liberation (*mokṣa-kāma*).

91 These four pious ones are greatly fortunate. Giving up their respective desires, they come to possess pure devotion.

92 By the mercy of the company of saints, or by Kṛṣṇa's mercy, they give up the "bad company" of desires and the like and attain pure devotion.

93 "A wise person who has been freed from bad company through the company of saints can never give up the captivating glory of the Lord once he has heard it sung." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.10.11)

94 By "bad company" I mean deceit (*kaitava*), self-deception: the desire for anything other than Kṛṣṇa and devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

95 "In this beautiful *Bhāgavatam*, composed by the great sage, is taught the supreme dharma of the saintly who are free from envy, from which all deceit has been cast out. Here is known the true Reality, which bestows good and uproots the threefold miseries. What need is there of other scriptures? As soon as the pious wish to hear it, the Lord is at once captured within their hearts." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.2)

96 By the prefix *pra* (in *projjhita*) the desire for liberation is shown to be the chief deceit. So Śrīdhara Svāmī has explained this verse.

97 Knowing a devotee with desires to be ignorant, the merciful Bhagavān gives him His own feet and so covers over his desires.

98 "It is true that when men ask, the Lord grants what they ask for; but He does not give what would make them ask again. To those who worship Him, though they do not desire it, He Himself gives His own feet, tender as

new shoots, which put an end to all other desires." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 5.19.26)

99 The company of saints, Kṛṣṇa's mercy and the very nature of *bhakti* — these three make one give up everything else and awaken *bhāva* for Kṛṣṇa.

100 In all the meanings I shall explain from here on, know this to be the cause of relishing Kṛṣṇa's qualities.

101 I have given this outline for the sake of explaining the verse. Now I shall reveal the verse's basic meaning.

102 On the path of knowledge the worshippers are of two kinds: those who worship Brahman alone (*kevala-brahmopāsaka*) and those who long for liberation (*mokṣākāṅkṣī*).

103 Those who worship Brahman alone are of three kinds: the *sādhaka* (beginner), the *brahmamaya* (absorbed in Brahman) and the *prāpta-brahma-laya* (merged in Brahman).

104 Without *bhakti*, by knowledge alone, there is no liberation. It is one who practises the *sādhana* of *bhakti* who reaches merging in Brahman (*prāpta-brahma-laya*).

105 The nature of *bhakti* is that it draws one away from Brahman; giving one a divine body, it makes one worship Kṛṣṇa.

106 On obtaining the body of a devotee, one remembers Kṛṣṇa's qualities; attracted by those qualities, one worships Him with pure devotion.

107 "Even the liberated, assuming a form (*vigraha*) by the Lord's *līlā*, worship Bhagavān." (Sarvajña-bhāṣya)

108 From birth Śuka, Sanaka and the others were *brahmamaya*, absorbed in Brahman; attracted by Kṛṣṇa's qualities, they worship Kṛṣṇa.

109 By Kṛṣṇa's mercy the minds of Sanaka and the others were stolen by the fragrance of His feet; attracted by His qualities, they worship Him with pure devotion.

110 "The breeze that bore the fragrance of tulasī, mingled with the pollen of the lotus-eyed Lord's lotus feet, entered their nostrils and stirred both their minds and their bodies, though they were devoted to the imperishable Brahman." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.15.43)

111 By Vyāsa's mercy Śukadeva came to remember Kṛṣṇa's pastimes; attracted by Kṛṣṇa's qualities, he worships Him.

112 "His mind captivated by the qualities of Hari, the great Śukadeva, son of Bādarāyaṇa, who is ever dear to the devotees of Viṣṇu, studied this great narration." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.7.11)

113 The nine Yogendras were *sādhaka* *jñānīs* from birth. Having heard of Kṛṣṇa's qualities from the mouths of Brahmā, Śiva and Nārada,

114 they were attracted by those qualities and worshipped Kṛṣṇa. Their devotion is described in the Eleventh Canto.

115 "Entering the assembly of the lotus-born Brahmā, which is free from all distress, the nine Yogendras, knowers of the Śruti, heard the Upaniṣads there; yet, their bodies thrilling with rapture, they went to the lofty *raṅga-kṣetra* to meet the Lord in the city of the Yadus." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Paścima-vibhāga, Śānta-bhakti-laharī, 20)

116 *Jñānīs* who long for liberation are of three kinds: the *mumukṣu* (seeker of liberation), the *jīvan-mukta* (liberated while living) and the

prāpta-svarūpa (one who has attained his true nature).

117 In the world there are many *mumukṣus*, people attached to worldly life, who worship Kṛṣṇa with devotion for the sake of liberation.

118 “Those who seek liberation give up the lords of beings, whose forms are terrible, though they bear them no envy; peaceful, they worship the partial forms (*kalā*) of Nārāyaṇa.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.2.26)

119 In the company of sādhus, Kṛṣṇa’s qualities are revealed to all of them; that company leads them to worship Kṛṣṇa and makes them give up the desire for liberation.

120 “O great soul, this worldly existence is corrupted by many faults, yet it shines with one quality, called the company of saints, which brings happiness: by it our desire for liberation has today been made weak.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Paścima-vibhāga, Prīti-bhakti-laharī, 27)

121 In the company of Nārada, Śaunaka and the other sages gave up the desire for liberation and worshipped Kṛṣṇa.

122 Some on seeing Kṛṣṇa, and some by Kṛṣṇa’s mercy, give up the desire for liberation and, drawn by His qualities, worship His feet.

123 “Now that Kṛṣṇa, the Supreme Self, whose form is concentrated bliss, has appeared here in Vṛṣṇi-pattana, I see — alas! — that for a long time my days passed in vain in being an *ātmārāma*.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Paścima-vibhāga, Śānta-bhakti-laharī, 34)

124 There are many who are liberated while living (*jīvan-mukta*), and I know them to be of two kinds: those liberated while living through devotion and those liberated while living through knowledge.

125 One liberated while living through devotion is attracted by Kṛṣṇa's qualities and worships Him; but one "liberated while living" through dry knowledge sinks down because of his offences.

126 "O lotus-eyed Lord, others think themselves liberated, but their intelligence is impure, for they have no love for You. Though they rise with great hardship to the supreme position, they fall down from there, having neglected Your feet." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.2.32)

127 "One who has realised Brahman and is serene within neither grieves nor desires. Equal to all beings, he attains supreme devotion to Me." (Bhagavad-gītā, 18.54)

128 "I was worshipped by those who walk the path of non-dualism, and I had received initiation on the throne of the bliss of the self; yet a certain rogue, a lover of the cowherd maidens, has forcibly made me a maidservant." (Śrī Kṛṣṇa-karṇāmṛta)

129 By the strength of bhakti, one who has attained his true nature (*prāpta-svarūpa*) receives a divine body. Attracted by Kṛṣṇa's qualities, he worships Kṛṣṇa's feet.

130 "*Nirodha* is the lying down to rest of the self, together with its potencies, following (the mystic slumber of the Lord). *Mukti* is to give up the other form and be established in one's own true nature (*svarūpa*)." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.10.6)

131 The fault of turning away from Kṛṣṇa comes from māyā, and freedom from māyā comes from liberation that is turned toward Kṛṣṇa.[1]

132 "For one who has turned away from the Lord, fear arises from absorption in what is other than Him; by His māyā come forgetfulness of the Lord and a false idea of oneself. Therefore the wise, seeing the guru as

his worshipful deity and his very self, should worship the Lord with exclusive devotion." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.37)

133 "This divine māyā of Mine, made of the guṇas, is hard to overcome. But those who surrender to Me alone cross beyond this māyā." (Bhagavad-gītā, 7.14)

134 Without bhakti there is no liberation; liberation comes through bhakti. And one who has attained liberation through bhakti surely worships Kṛṣṇa.

135 "O almighty Lord, bhakti to You is the path to the highest good. Those who reject it and toil only to gain knowledge are left with nothing but their toil, like those who pound empty husks." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.4)

136 "O lotus-eyed Lord, others think themselves liberated, but their intelligence is impure, for they have no love for You. Though they rise with great hardship to the supreme position, they fall down from there, having neglected Your feet." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.2.32)

137 "Those among them who do not worship the Puruṣa, their own source and Lord, but disregard Him, fall from their position and sink into the depths." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.3)

138 "Even the liberated, assuming a form (*vigraha*) by the Lord's *līlā*, worship Bhagavān." (Sarvajña-bhāṣya)

139 These six kinds of *ātmārāmas* worship Kṛṣṇa. The word *ca*, joined to each of them separately, here expresses the sense of *api* ("also").

140 "*Ātmārāmāś ca api*": even the *ātmārāmas* render causeless devotion to Kṛṣṇa. "*Munayaḥ santaḥ*" — "being sages" — means that they become attached to contemplating Kṛṣṇa.

141 "*Nirgranthāḥ*" means free from ignorance (*avidyā*), and for some it means free from rules (*vidhi*). Wherever a meaning fits, the word takes that meaning.

142 If I give the word *ca* the sense of *itaretara* (mutual connection), it yields yet another most cogent meaning.

143 Repeating "*ātmārāmāś ca ātmārāmāś ca*" six times, five of the six *ātmārāmas* are dropped together with their *ca*.

144 A single word *ātmārāmaḥ* remains, and that one word denotes all six.

145 "Of words of the same form in the same case only one remains (*eka-śeṣa*); words whose meaning has already been expressed are not used: thus '*rāmaś ca rāmaś ca rāmaś ca*' becomes '*rāmāḥ*'." (Viśva-prakāśa)

146 The word *ca* that then remains expresses conjunction (*samuccaya*): "the *ātmārāmas* and the sages (*ātmārāmāś ca munayaś ca*)" worship Kṛṣṇa.

147 In "*nirgranthā api*," this *api* has the sense of possibility (*sambhāvanā*). These are the seven meanings that I have explained first.

148 One who worships the Antaryāmī, the Lord within the heart, is also called an *ātmārāma*, and these *ātmārāma* yogīs are of two kinds.

149 *Sagarbha* and *nirgarbha* — these are the two kinds. Each of them is of three kinds, and so there are six divisions.

150 "Some, by concentration (*dhāraṇā*), remember the Person who dwells in the space of the heart within their own body: He is a span in size, four-armed, and holds the lotus, the disc, the conch and the mace." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.2.8)

151 “Having thus gained *bhāva* for Bhagavān Hari, his heart melting with devotion and the hair of his body standing on end with joy, again and again overwhelmed by streams of tears of longing, the yogī gradually withdraws even the hook of his mind (from the object of meditation).” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.28.34)

152 *Yogārurukṣu* (one who wishes to rise to yoga), *yogārūḍha* (one who has risen to yoga) and *prāpta-siddhi* (one who has attained perfection): by these three divisions there are six kinds.

153 “For the sage who wishes to ascend to yoga, action is said to be the means; for that same sage, once he has risen to yoga, tranquillity (*śama*) is said to be the means.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 6.3)

154 “When one is attached neither to the objects of the senses nor to actions, and has renounced all intentions (*saṅkalpa*), he is then called *yogārūḍha*, one who has risen to yoga.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 6.4)

155 These six kinds of yogīs, obtaining such causes as the company of sādhus, become attracted by Kṛṣṇa’s qualities and worship Kṛṣṇa.

156 Here too the word *ca* expresses the meaning of *api*, and the words *muni* and *nirgrantha* have the same meanings as before.

157 The words *urukrame* and *ahaitukī* take whichever meaning fits each case. Thus I have told you thirteen most cogent meanings.

158 When all these peaceful ones (*śānta*) worship Bhagavān, I then call them *śānta* devotees.

159 The word *ātmā* also means the mind (*mana*). One who delights in the mind worships Śrī Kṛṣṇa’s feet in the company of sādhus.

160 “Those of gross vision who follow the paths of the ṛṣis worship (Brahman in) the belly (*udara*); the Āruṇis worship (Brahman, the) subtle (*dahara*), in the heart, from which the channels branch out. From there, O Ananta, (the path) rises to the head, Your supreme abode; having reached it, they do not fall again into the jaws of death in this world.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.87.18)

161 Attracted by Kṛṣṇa’s qualities, they become great sages and, becoming *nirgrantha*, render causeless devotion.

162 The word *ātmā* also means effort (*yatna*). Making effort, even sages (*munayo ’pi*) become *nirgrantha* and worship Kṛṣṇa.

163 “The wise should strive for that alone which is not obtained by those who wander through the worlds above and below. Happiness, like suffering, comes of itself everywhere, brought by time, whose course is irresistible.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.5.18)

164 “Those whose minds are set with perseverance on understanding true religion soon attain every aim they desire.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Pūrva-vibhāga, Sādhana-bhakti-laharī, 47)

165 The word *ca* has the sense of *api*, and *api* the sense of certainty (*avadhāraṇa*): without eager longing (*yatnāgraha*), bhakti does not give birth to love (*prema*).

166 “Bhakti is very hard to attain in two ways: by multitudes of *sādhanas* performed without *āsaṅga*, eager longing, it cannot be attained even in a very long time; and Hari does not give it quickly.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.1.35)

167 “To those who are ever devoted to Me and worship Me with love, I give the understanding that brings them to Me.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 10.10)

168 The word *ātmā* also means steadfastness (*dhṛti*). One who delights in steadfastness becomes steadfast and then worships (Kṛṣṇa).

169 The word *muni* also means a bird or a bumblebee, and *nirgrantha* a foolish person. By the mercy of Kṛṣṇa and the mercy of the sādhus, both of them worship (Kṛṣṇa).

170 “O mother, the birds of this forest are almost sages: they rise onto the branches of the trees, lovely with fresh shoots, to see Kṛṣṇa, and with eyes closed and all other sounds silenced, they listen to the sweet song of the flute that flows from Him.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.21.14)

171 “O original Person, these bees sing Your glory, which purifies all the worlds, and serve You by following You along Your path. They must be sages, the foremost of Your devotees: though You are hidden in the forest, O sinless one, they do not leave You, the Lord of their hearts.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.15.6)

172 “The cranes, swans and other birds of the lake, their hearts stolen by His lovely song, came near and, with minds controlled — ah! — with eyes closed and keeping silence, worshipped Hari.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.35.11)

173 “The Kirātas, Hūṇas, Andhras, Pulindas, Pukkaśas, Ābhīras, Śuhmas, Yavanas, Khaśas and others, and other sinful people too, are purified by taking shelter of those who have taken shelter of Him. Obeisance to that all-powerful Lord!” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.4.18)

174 Or the word *dhṛti* means the awareness of one’s own fullness: through the absence of suffering and the attainment of the highest, one becomes completely full.

175 "*Dhṛti* is the awareness of fullness that comes from the absence of suffering and the attainment of the highest. It frees one from lamenting over objects not attained, past or lost." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 2.4.144)

176 A devotee of Kṛṣṇa is free from suffering and free from other desires; he is versed in the full bliss of loving service to Kṛṣṇa.

177 "Fulfilled by serving Me, My devotees do not desire even the four kinds of liberation — *sālokya*, *sārūpya*, *sāmīpya* and *sārṣṭi* — that such service brings them of itself. How then would they seek worldly pleasures, or merging in Brahman? For all that is swept away by time." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 9.4.67)

178 "In this world of birth and death (*saṁsāra*), where all living beings are unsteady, he alone attains steadfastness whose senses have become steady in Hṛṣīkeśa, the Lord of the senses."

179 Here *ca* has the sense of certainty (*avadhāraṇa*), and *api* the sense of conjunction (*samuccaya*): birds and foolish people in great numbers become steadfast and worship (Kṛṣṇa).

180 The word *ātmā* also means intelligence (*buddhi*), that is, special intelligence; and all the countless living beings are endowed with ordinary intelligence.

181 The *ātmārāma* who delights in intelligence is of two kinds: the sages, who are learned (*paṇḍita*), and the *nirgranthas*, who are foolish (*mūrkha*).

182 By Kṛṣṇa's mercy, in the company of sādhus, one gains attachment (*rati*) and good intelligence. Giving up everything, with pure intelligence one attains devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

183 “I am the source of everything; everything proceeds from Me. Knowing this, the wise, endowed with *bhāva*, worship Me.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 10.8)

184 “Women, *śūdras*, Hūṇas, Śabaras and other sinful beings — even animals and birds — come to know (the Lord) and cross beyond the divine māyā if they learn the conduct of those devoted to Adbhuta-krama, the Lord of wondrous deeds. What then to speak of those who hold to the Śruti!” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.7.46)

185 When, after careful reflection, one worships Kṛṣṇa’s feet, Kṛṣṇa gives him the intelligence by which he attains Him.

186 “To those who are ever devoted to Me and worship Me with love, I give the understanding that brings them to Me.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 10.10)

187 The company of saints, service to Kṛṣṇa, the *Bhāgavata*, the holy Name and living in Vraja — these five are the principal *sādhanas*.

188 If a sensible person has even a slight (connection with) one of these five, love for Kṛṣṇa awakens in him.

189 “The power of these five limbs is wondrous and hard to grasp. Let alone faith in them: even the slightest connection with them gives birth to *bhāva* in those of good understanding, who are free from offence.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Pūrva-vibhāga, Sādhana-bhakti-laharī, 87)

190 One whose intelligence is broad, great and best of all may worship with various desires, yet he still attains perfection in bhakti.

191 “Whether he is without desire, full of every desire, or desirous of liberation, a person of broad intelligence should worship the Supreme Person with intense *bhakti-yoga*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.3.10)

192 Such is the power of bhakti: it makes one give up those desires and, attracting one by Kṛṣṇa's qualities, makes one render devotion to His feet.

193 "It is true that when men ask, the Lord grants what they ask for; but He does not give what would make them ask again. To those who worship Him, though they do not desire it, He Himself gives His own feet, tender as new shoots, which put an end to all other desires." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 5.19.26)

194 The word *ātmā* also means one's nature (*svabhāva*), and one who delights in it is an *ātmārāma*. Thus all living beings, stationary and moving, are *ātmārāmas*.

195 The nature of the *jīva* is to know himself as Kṛṣṇa's servant; that awareness becomes covered when he takes the body to be the self.

196 The word *ca* means *eva* ("indeed"), and the word *api* has the sense of conjunction: being *ātmārāmas* indeed (*ātmārāmā eva*), (all beings) worship Śrī Kṛṣṇa.

197 These *jīvas* are all the sages (*munis*), such as Sanaka and the others; and the *nirgranthas* are the foolish, the low, and the stationary and moving beings.

198 The worship of Vyāsa, Śuka, Sanaka and the others is well known. Now hear the account of the *nirgranthas* — the stationary beings and the rest.

199 Through such causes as Kṛṣṇa's mercy, their true nature (*svabhāva*) awakens, and, attracted by Kṛṣṇa's qualities, they worship Him.

200 "Today this earth is blessed; blessed are the grasses and shrubs that touch Your feet, the trees and creepers touched by Your fingers, the rivers,

mountains, birds and beasts on whom You cast Your merciful glances, and the gopīs held between Your arms — a place for which even Śrī (Lakṣmī) longs." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.15.8)

201 "O friends, as the two Brothers, marked by the ropes and nooses for tying the cows, lead the cows with the cowherd boys from forest to forest, the generous, sweet notes of Their flutes work wonders among embodied beings: those that move become still, and the trees thrill with ecstasy." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.21.19)

202 "The forest creepers and trees, rich with flowers and fruits, their branches bowed with the weight and their bodies thrilled with love, poured down streams of honey, as if revealing Viṣṇu within themselves." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.35.9)

203 "The Kirātas, Hūṇas, Andhras, Pulindas, Pukkaśas, Ābhīras, Śuhmas, Yavanas, Khaśas and others, and other sinful people too, are purified by taking shelter of those who have taken shelter of Him. Obeisance to that all-powerful Lord!" (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.4.18)

204 Earlier I gave thirteen meanings, and now these six: together they make nineteen meanings.

205 I have given these nineteen meanings; now hear more. The word *ātmā* also means the body (*deha*), and this gives four meanings.

206 One who delights in the body (*dehārāmī*) worships in the body a Brahman conditioned by the body; in the company of saints, he too comes to worship Kṛṣṇa.

207 "Those of gross vision who follow the paths of the ṛṣis worship (Brahman in) the belly (*udara*); the Āruṇis worship (Brahman, the) subtle (*dahara*), in the heart, from which the channels branch out. From there, O

Ananta, (the path) rises to the head, Your supreme abode; having reached it, they do not fall again into the jaws of death in this world." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.87.18)

208 Those who delight in the body and are devoted to karma — performers of sacrifice and the like — give up karma in the company of saints and worship (Kṛṣṇa).

209 "In this sacrificial work, whose fruit is never certain, we have been blackened by the smoke; but you give us to drink the honeyed nectar (*āsava*) of Govinda's lotus feet." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.18.12)

210 Ascetics (*tapasvī*) and the like are all *dehārāmīs*, those who delight in the body; in the company of sādhus they give up austerity and worship Śrī Kṛṣṇa.

211 "The taste for serving His feet, increasing day by day, at once destroys the impurity that has gathered in the minds of ascetics through countless births, as does the river (Gaṅgā) that flows from the toe of His foot." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 4.21.31)

212 Those who delight in the body and are full of desires are all *ātmārāmas*; by Kṛṣṇa's mercy they give up all desires and worship Kṛṣṇa.

213 "Desiring a high position, I engaged in austerities, and I have attained You, who are hidden even from the gods and the greatest sages. I was searching for a piece of glass and found a divine jewel. O Master, my purpose is fulfilled; I ask for no boon." (Hari-bhakti-sudhodaya, 7.28)

214 Together with these four, there are twenty-three meanings. Now hear three more most cogent meanings.

215 The word *ca* in the sense of conjunction (*samuccaya*) gives another meaning: “the *ātmārāmas* and the sages (*ātmārāmāś ca munayaś ca*)” worship Kṛṣṇa.

216 “Becoming *nirgranthas*”: here *api* has the sense of specification (*nirdhāraṇa*), as in “*rāmaś ca kṛṣṇaś ca* roam in the forest.”

217 The word *ca* gives yet another meaning in the sense of *anvācaya* — adding something secondary to what is principal — as in: “*Baṭo, bhikṣām aṭa, gāṁ cānaya*” (“O boy, go for alms, and bring the cow too”).

218 The sage, absorbed in contemplating Kṛṣṇa, always worships Kṛṣṇa; and “the *ātmārāmas* also (*ātmārāmā api*)” worship Him — this expresses the secondary meaning.

219 Taking *ca* in the sense of *eva*: “only the sages (*munayaḥ eva*)” worship Kṛṣṇa; and in “*ātmārāmā api*” the word *api* expresses censure (*garhā*).

220 “Becoming *nirgranthas*” is a qualifier of both. Now hear another meaning, which shows what the company of sādhus can do.

221 The word *nirgrantha* then means a hunter (*vyādha*) or a pauper (*nirdhana*); in the company of sādhus, he too worships Śrī Kṛṣṇa.

222 “*Kṛṣṇārāmāś ca*”: those who delight in Kṛṣṇa, that is, in contemplating Kṛṣṇa. Though a hunter, such a person becomes worshipful, the best of the *bhāgavatas*.

223 Hear attentively the story of a hunter who became a devotee; from it one comes to know the glory of the company of saints.

224 One day, after seeing Nārāyaṇa, Śrī Nārada went to Prayāga to bathe at the Triveṇī.

225 On the forest path he saw a deer lying on the ground, pierced by an arrow, its legs broken, writhing in pain.

226 A little farther on he saw a boar, likewise pierced, its legs broken, writhing in pain.

227 A little farther on he saw a rabbit in the same state. Seeing the suffering of these creatures, Nārada was distressed at heart.

228 A little farther on he saw the hunter hiding behind a tree, an arrow fitted to his bow, waiting to kill deer.

229 He was dark in complexion, red-eyed and very fearsome; with bow and arrows in his hands, he looked like Yamarāja holding his rod of punishment.

230 Leaving the path, Nārada went up to him, and on seeing Nārada all the deer ran away.

231 The hunter grew angry and wanted to abuse him, but by Nārada's power no abuse would come to his lips.

232 "Gosāñi, why have you left the road (*prayāṇa-patha*) and come here? Seeing you, the deer I was aiming at has fled."

233 Nārada said, "I lost my way and have come to ask you something. There is a doubt in my mind, and I would like to dispel it.

234 The boar and the deer on the path — I take it they are yours?" The hunter said, "Yes, what you say is so."

235 Nārada said, “If you shoot living beings with your arrows, why do you leave them half-dead instead of taking their lives?”

236 The hunter replied, “Listen, gosāñi: my name is Mṛgāri, ‘enemy of the beasts.’ I do this work just as my father taught me.

237 “When a half-killed creature writhes and thrashes about, the joy in my heart swells.”

238 Nārada said, “I ask one thing of you.” The hunter said, “Take a deer or any other animal you like.

239 “If you want a deerskin, come to my house. I will give you whatever you want — a deerskin or a tiger skin.”

240 Nārada said, “I want none of these. I ask another gift of you:

241 “From tomorrow on, whatever animals you kill, kill them outright; do not leave them half-dead.”

242 The hunter said, “What a gift to ask of me! What harm is there in half-killing them? Tell me that.”

243 Nārada said, “A half-killed creature suffers pain. You are giving pain to living beings, and the same plight will be yours.

244 “You are a hunter and you kill animals — that is a small offense. But to kill them by torment — that sin is boundless.

245 “All the creatures you have tormented to death will kill you in the same way, birth after birth.”

246 In Nārada's company the hunter's mind became clear, and on hearing his words he grew afraid.

247 The hunter said, "This has been my work since childhood. How can I, a sinful and fallen wretch, be delivered?

248 "By what means will this sin of mine be removed? Deliver me — I fall at your feet."

249 Nārada said, "If you accept my word, then I can set you free."

250 The hunter said, "Whatever you say, I will do." Nārada said, "Break your bow; then I will tell you."

251 The hunter said, "If I break my bow, how will I live?" Nārada said, "I will give you food every day."

252 The hunter broke his bow and fell at Nārada's feet. Nārada raised him up and instructed him:

253 "Go home and give the brāhmaṇas whatever wealth you have. Then leave home, both of you, each wearing a single cloth.

254 "Build a small hut on the bank of a river, and in front of it plant a tulasī on a raised mound.

255 "Walk around the tulasī and serve her, and chant the name of Kṛṣṇa without cease.

256 "I will send you plenty of food every day. Take of it only as much as the two of you eat."

257 Then Nārada healed the three wounded animals, and once healed they ran off and were gone.

258 Seeing this, the hunter was astonished. He bowed to his guru and went home.

259 Nārada went on his way, and the hunter went home and did everything Nārada had told him.

260 Word spread through the village that the hunter had become a Vaiṣṇava, and all the villagers began to bring him food.

261 In a single day ten or twenty people would bring food, but each day he took only as much as the two of them would eat.

262 One day Nārada said to Parvata, “Listen, I have a disciple. Let us go and see him.”

263 So the two sages came to the hunter’s place, and the hunter caught sight of his guru from afar.

264 He came running in haste, yet he could find no place to step, for here and there the ants on the path were at his feet.

265 Seeing ants where he was to offer his prostration, he swept the place clear with his cloth and then fell flat like a rod.

266 Nārada said, “Hunter, this is no wonder. Through devotion to Hari the best of saints becomes free of all violence.”

267 “O hunter, it is no wonder that you have non-violence and these other virtues: those who are engaged in devotion to Hari never cause pain to others.” (Skanda-purāṇa)

268 Then the hunter brought the two sages into his courtyard, fetched seats of *kuśa* grass and reverently seated them.

269 He brought water and reverently washed the feet of both, and he and his wife drank that water and placed it on their heads.

270 As he sang the name of Kṛṣṇa, he trembled, his hair stood on end and tears flowed; and he danced with arms raised, waving his cloth.

271 Seeing the hunter's love, the great sage Parvata said to Nārada, "You are a touchstone!

272 "Ah, O sage among the gods, you are blessed! By your mercy even a lowly hunter at once attained love (*rati*) for Acyuta, his hair standing on end." (Skanda-purāṇa)

273 Nārada said, "Vaiṣṇava, does any food come to you?" The hunter said, "Whoever you send brings something and leaves it.

274 "Do not send so much food; there is no need. We want only as much food as is fit for two people."

275 Nārada said, "Live like this — you are fortunate." With these words the two sages vanished.

276 Thus I have told you the story of the hunter. Whoever hears it comes to know the power of the company of *sādhus*.

277 These three further meanings are added to the count, and the two sets of meanings together come to twenty-six.

278 Hear another meaning — a storehouse of meanings: broadly it is twofold, and in finer detail it is of thirty-two kinds.

279 The word *ātmā* means Bhagavān in all His forms: one is Svayaṁ Bhagavān, the Lord Himself, and the others are called Bhagavān.

280 All who delight in Him are *ātmārāmas*. They are of two kinds by name: devotees who follow the rules (*vidhi-bhakta*) and devotees of spontaneous attachment (*rāga-bhakta*).

281 Each of these two kinds of devotees is of four kinds: the eternal associates (*pārṣada*), those perfected by practice (*sādhana-siddha*) and the practitioners (*sādhaka*).

282 The practitioners are of two kinds, according to whether *rati* has awakened in them or not. So on the paths of *vidhi* and *rāga* there are four and four — eight kinds.

283 On the path of *vidhi-bhakti*, the eternally perfect associates (*nitya-siddha pārṣada*) appear in four kinds: servants, friends, elders and beloveds.

284 Those perfected by practice are servants, friends, elders and beloveds; and the practitioners in whom *rati* has awakened are also of four kinds.

285 The practitioners in whom *rati* has not yet awakened are of these four kinds as well. Thus on the path of *vidhi* the devotees are known in sixteen kinds.

286 On the path of *rāga* the devotees are likewise of sixteen kinds, so that on the two paths there are thirty-two kinds of *ātmārāmas*.

287 The meanings of the four words *muni*, *nirgrantha*, *ca* and *api* I apply wherever each of them fits.

288 The thirty-two and the twenty-six together make fifty-eight. Now hear yet another way of bringing out the meaning.

289 Joining them with *ca* in the sense of mutual conjunction (*itaretara*), I take the word *ātmārāma* fifty-eight times:

290 "*ātmārāmāś ca ātmārāmāś ca*" — fifty-eight times. Then, dropping all the rest, I keep the word only once.

291 "Of words of the same form in the same case only one remains (*eka-śeṣa*); words whose meaning has already been expressed are not used." (Viśva-prakāśa)

292 All fifty-eight occurrences of *ca* are elided, and the single word *ātmārāma* expresses fifty-eight meanings.

293 "Of words of the same form in the same case only one remains (*eka-śeṣa*); words whose meaning has already been expressed are not used." (Pāṇini, 1.2.64)

294 "*Aśvattha* trees and banyan trees and *kapittha* trees and mango trees — trees."

295 Just as one says, "In this forest the trees bear fruit," so all the *ātmārāmas* render devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

296 In "*ātmārāmāś ca*" I take the word *ca* in the sense of conjunction (*samuccaya*): "and the *munis* render devotion" — this is its meaning.

297 Taking "*nirgranthā eva*" — "having become *nirgranthas*" — and *api* in the sense of specification (*nirdhāraṇa*), I have explained the fifty-ninth kind of meaning.

298 Conjoining them all, there is one more meaning: “The *ātmārāmas*, the *munis* and the *nirgranthas*” all worship Kṛṣṇa.

299 Taking the word *api* in the sense of certainty (*avadhāraṇa*), I will pronounce *eva* four times, once with each of the four words:

300 “To Urukrama alone, devotion alone, causeless devotion alone — this indeed they render.”

301 Thus I have told you sixty meanings of the verse. Now hear one more meaning, well supported by evidence.

302 The word *ātmā* also denotes the *jīva*, the knower of the field (*kṣetrajña*). All beings, from Brahmā down to the insect, are counted as His potency.

303 “The potency of Viṣṇu is declared to be superior; the potency called the knower of the field (*kṣetrajña*) is likewise superior; and the other, called ignorance and karma, is held to be a third potency.” (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 6.7.61)

304 “*Kṣetrajña*: *ātmā*, *puruṣa*, *pradhāna* and *prakṛti* (the last in the feminine).” (Amara-kośa)

305 If, after wandering and wandering, such a soul finds the company of a *sādhu*, he gives up everything and worships Kṛṣṇa.

306 I have told you sixty meanings, and all of them concern the worship of Kṛṣṇa; that same meaning holds in all these examples.

307 Now, in your company, the sixty-first meaning has come to light. By the power of your devotion, waves of meaning rise up.

308 Hearing these meanings, Sanātana was amazed. Clasping Mahāprabhu's feet, he offered prayers:

309 "You are the Lord Himself, the son of the king of Vraja. All the Vedas come forth with Your breath.

310 "You are the speaker of the *Bhāgavatam*, and You know its meaning. No one but You is able to know it."

311 The Lord said, "Why do you praise Me? Why do you not consider the true nature of the *Bhāgavatam*?

312 "The *Bhāgavatam* is equal to Kṛṣṇa — all-pervading, the shelter of all. In every verse and every syllable it expresses many meanings.

313 "In the *Bhāgavatam* the truth is established through questions and answers, and hearing it, people are struck with wonder.

314 "I know, Śuka knows, and Vyāsa may or may not know. The *Bhāgavatam* is to be grasped by devotion — not by the intellect, nor by commentaries." (An ancient verse: the words of Śiva)

315 "Tell us: now that Kṛṣṇa — the master of *yoga*, devoted to the *brāhmaṇas*, the armour of *dharma* — has gone to His own abode, to whom has *dharma* gone for shelter?" (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.23)

316 "Now that Kṛṣṇa has gone to His own abode together with *dharma*, knowledge and the rest, this Purāṇa has risen like the sun in the age of Kali for those who have lost their sight." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.3.43)

317 "In this way I have explained a single verse. Who would take a madman's raving as authority?

318 “Only one who becomes ‘mad’ like Me comes to know the meaning of the *Bhāgavatam* with such vision.”

319 Joining his palms, Sanātana spoke again: “Lord, You ordered me to compile a *Vaiṣṇava-smṛti*.

320 “I am of low birth and know nothing of reasoning. How can a *smṛti* be set forth through me?

321 “If You instruct me, showing the direction in the form of *sūtras*, and if You Yourself enter my heart,

322 “then the way to write it will dawn in this lowly one’s heart. You are the Lord: whatever You have one do is accomplished.”

323 The Lord said, “Whatever you resolve to do, Kṛṣṇa will reveal it to you.

324 “Still, hear an outline of these *sūtras*. First describe, with its reasons, taking shelter of a guru.

325 “the marks of a guru and of a disciple, and how each tests the other; Bhagavān as the object of service; a consideration of all the *mantras*;

326 “who is qualified to receive a *mantra*; the purification of a *mantra*, its perfection and the like; initiation; the morning duties of remembrance; cleanliness; *ācamana*;

327 “cleaning the teeth, bathing, the *sandhyā* and other prayers; service to the guru; wearing the *ūrdhva-puṇḍra*, the *cakra* and the other marks;

328 “wearing *gopī-candana* and beads; gathering *tulasī*; purifying the cloth, the altar and the house; awakening Kṛṣṇa;

329 “worship with five, sixteen or fifty articles of offering; *pūjā* and *ārati* at the five times of day; offering Kṛṣṇa His meals and laying Him to rest;

330 “the marks of the Deity and of the *śālagrāma*; pilgrimage to Kṛṣṇa’s holy places; beholding Kṛṣṇa’s Deity form;

331 “the glory of the name and keeping far from offenses against the name; the marks of a Vaiṣṇava; overcoming offenses in service;

332 “the characteristics of the conch, water, fragrance, flowers, incense and the rest; *japa*, prayers, circumambulation and prostrate obeisances;

333 “the rules of *puraścaraṇa*; honouring Kṛṣṇa’s *prasāda*; rejecting what has not been offered; avoiding blasphemy of Vaiṣṇavas and the like;

334 “the marks of a *sādhu*, the company of *sādhus* and service to them; giving up bad company; hearing *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam*;

335 “the daily and fortnightly duties, with an account of Ekādaśī and other days; the monthly duties; a consideration of the rules for Janmāṣṭamī and the other holy days —

336 “Ekādaśī, Janmāṣṭamī, Vāmana-dvādaśī, Śrī Rāma-navamī and Nṛsiṁha-caturdaśī.

337 “For all of these, reject a ‘pierced’ (*viddhā*) day and observe an unpierced one. Not observing them is a fault; by observing them one attains *bhakti*.

338 “Everywhere give the words of the Purāṇas as evidence. Describe also the rules for installing Deities and building temples of Viṣṇu;

339 “general good conduct and Vaiṣṇava conduct; what should and should not be done; and the practices of the *smārtas*.

340 “Thus I have given you a brief outline. When you write, Kṛṣṇa will reveal it to you.”

341 Thus I have told of the Lord’s mercy to Sanātana. Hearing of it dispels the heart’s despondency.

342 Karṇapūra has described at length in his own book the Lord’s mercy to Sanātana and set it down in writing:

343 “This very one — the elder brother of Rūpa, once the jewel adorning the court of the king of Gauḍa — gave up abundant wealth and took as his own the youthful goddess of renunciation. Within he is a lake brimming with the *rasa* of devotion; outwardly he looks like an *avadhūta*. Like a great lake covered with moss, he gives delight to those who know him.” (Caitanya-candrodaya, Act 9)

344 “The moment Sanātana came within sight of His eyes, the Lord, golden as a *campaka* flower, melted with boundless compassion and tenderly embraced him with His long arms, mighty as bolts.” (Caitanya-candrodaya, Act 9)

345 “Since over time the account of the pastimes of Vṛndāvana had been lost, the Lord, to make it known in a special way, sprinkled Rūpa and Sanātana there with the nectar of His mercy.” (Caitanya-candrodaya, 9.38)

346 Thus I have told of the Lord’s mercy to Sanātana. Hearing of it dispels the heart’s despondency.

347 Here is knowledge of all of Kṛṣṇa’s forms (*svarūpa*) and the injunctions of *sādhana-bhakti* on the paths of *vidhi* and *rāga*;

348 love of Kṛṣṇa, the *rasa* of devotion and the conclusions of *bhakti*. By hearing this a devotee comes to know them all to the very end.

349 One whose life's treasure is the feet of Śrī Caitanya, Nityānanda and Advaita attains this treasure.

350 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. The Gauḍīya Maṭha edition reads *kṛṣṇonmukhī mukti*, "liberation turned toward Kṛṣṇa"; another reading has *kṛṣṇonmukha bhakti … māyā-mukta haya*, "through devotion turned toward Kṛṣṇa one is freed from māyā." According to the *Anubhāṣya*, freedom from māyā comes through serving Kṛṣṇa, that is, through turning toward Him. ↩